



BEFORE

By 1861, the medical profession was transforming itself from one rooted in guesswork, gut instinct, and folklore, into a more scientific vocation.

MODERN MEDICINE

The old 18th-century ideas of “**miasmic vapors**” and imbalances in bodily “**humors**” were giving way to **modern medical practices and theories**. Education of doctors and nurses still varied widely. Some people were required to graduate from university programs and **others learned by experience, including experimentation on Black people**. Diagnosis, prescription, therapy, and even surgery often took place at the patient’s home, sometimes on the kitchen table. **Formal hospitals were rare**, and existed only in big cities.

WARTIME TREATMENT

At the time of the war, **surgical techniques were crude**, often involving rough amputations and probing of wounds to **extract foreign objects**. Luckily for most injured soldiers, anesthesia—in the form of ether and chloroform—was given..

When the war began, the U.S. Army’s medical corps was comprised of one surgeon general, 30 surgeons, and 83 assistant surgeons; 24 resigned to serve the Confederacy. These men became the core of the Union and Confederate medical departments; by the war’s end, almost 12,000 doctors had been employed by the North and 3,237 by the South.

This massive wartime expansion was necessitated by the unprecedented scale of the conflict and the high number of injured troops. Not everyone was qualified for their duties; many had been medical students before the war or learned on the job as surgeon’s assistants, but both sides lowered standards in order to fill the need for doctors. Civilian contractors and volunteers helped plug the gaps that the uniformed medical services could not fill, especially in the first two years. Volunteer nurses and relief organizations—such as the U.S. Sanitary Commission in the North and the Association for the Relief of Maimed Soldiers in the South—proved crucial in saving lives after major battles. In the South, private homes often served as makeshift hospitals, their female occupants providing Confederates with more personalized care than they might otherwise have received.